

Scaffolding over the Taj Mahal to protect it during wartime

The first real threat to the building came in 1984, when Punjabi Sikhs seeking to create their own Sikh-controlled state were besieged in the Harmandir Sahib (the "Golden Temple") in the city of Amritsar. The government stormed the building, creating outrage amongst Sikhs around the globe. While the operation was successful in putting down the open revolt, it created widespread anti-government sentiments amongst Sikhs and led to a number of Sikh nationalist groups. One result was the assassination of the Prime Minister Indira Gandhi by her Sikh bodyguards, and in this context, it was feared that the Taj, the ultimate symbol of Indian power and splendor, would be attacked out of revenge for damage done to the Harmandir Sahib[57].

More recently, the site has also been targeted by militant Sunni Muslims claiming affinity to Al-Qaeda. These groups see the Persian and Shiite-inspired shrine as a glorification of a mortal and therefore a distraction from true Islam; the fact that it has become a symbol of India, the rival of (overwhelmingly Sunni) Muslim Pakistan, only makes it a better target.[58] These threats became more tangible after the Taliban's destruction of the Buddhas of Bamiyan in 2001, which showed that the fundamentalists were not